

Incremental Progression Redesign Recommendations

A design review focused on resource flow, skill-tree pacing, active play, and making Lineage / Cultivars feel worthy of the reset.



Prepared from the current game HTML supplied on 24 August 2026, plus gameplay observations from repeated Vintage / Succession / Lineage progression.

Executive summary

Core diagnosis

The game has the right ingredients for a strong incremental - layered prestige, production bottlenecks, a persistent skill tree, achievements and cultivars - but several systems currently encourage players to bypass the decisions those layers are supposed to create.

The four highest-impact problems are:

- Fruit is both the Grove currency and the Press capital currency, so investing in conversion directly competes with expanding the economy that funds conversion.
- Terroir is only a price gate. The optimal play can become "save enough Terroir, then buy essentially the whole skill tree at once" instead of progressively shaping a build.
- Tending rewards input frequency rather than timing or decision-making. Holding Space converts keyboard repeat into optimal active play.
- Cultivars are often too incremental for the severity of a Lineage reset. The rarest prestige layer should change the rules of the game, not merely add another modest multiplier.

Recommended redesign in one sentence: give each production stage its own capital loop, make the skill tree progression-gated as well as currency-gated, replace click spam with a charged Vigour action, and make Cultivars permanent rule changes with a baseline reward for every Lineage.

Recommendations at a glance

System	Current issue	Recommended change	Desired outcome
Grove / Press economy	Trees and Presses both spend Fruit	Add a Press-specific by-product currency such as Pomace	No more conflict between growing the orchard and financing Press capacity
Skill tree	Terroir hoarding can buy the tree in one burst	Add Knowledge / milestone gates alongside Terroir	Build evolves over multiple Vintages and reflects actual play
Tending	Hold Space = optimal active play	Use Vigour as a charged harvest with timing bonuses	Active play becomes a decision, not APM
Cultivars	Rare reset, modest payoff	Make Cultivars remove constraints / change rules	Every Lineage visibly changes how the estate plays
Lineage	Can feel like erasing progress for unused Seeds	Permanent Lineage multiplier in addition to Seeds	Every Lineage is worthwhile even before the next purchase
Prestige layers	Roles overlap and can feel like reset-for-number	Give Vintage / Succession / Lineage distinct jobs	Clear short-, medium- and long-term goals

1. Separate the Grove and Press capital economies

Current behaviour

The current implementation intentionally gives Casks their own Must sink, but Trees and Presses still share Fruit. Presses also intercept live Grove production before it reaches the Fruit stockpile. That creates a real trade-off, but at scale it becomes a structural conflict rather than an interesting choice.

Why this becomes awkward

The player can be correct to leave the Press bottleneck unresolved because a stronger Press reduces spendable Fruit while Fruit is simultaneously required to buy more Press. A red bottleneck can therefore be optimal during the growth phase.

Recommended model

Stage	Produces	Capital currency	Capital buys
Grove	Fruit	Fruit	Trees / Grove upgrades
Press	Must + Pomace	Pomace	Presses / Press upgrades
Cellar	Bottles	Must (or Lees, optional)	Casks / Cellar upgrades

Suggested Pomace implementation

- Generate Pomace as a fixed percentage of Fruit actually pressed (for example 10-20%).
- Price Press buildings and Press-specific upgrades in Pomace instead of Fruit.
- Keep Must as the throughput resource that feeds Cellar, so production and capital still interact without competing for the same wallet.
- Optionally allow a small number of cross-stage upgrades to cost mixed resources, but make them the exception rather than the baseline.

Resulting positive feedback loops

Grove loop	Press loop	Cellar loop
More Trees -> more Fruit -> more Trees	More Press -> more Pomace + Must -> more Press	More Must -> more Casks -> more Bottles

Alternative if a new currency is undesirable

Use a derived Press Capacity resource instead of Pomace: every N Fruit processed grants a permanent-in-Vintage "Engineering" point that pays for Presses. This achieves the same separation without adding a visible inventory resource.

2. Make the skill tree progression-gated, not just expensive

The updated game raised per-rank cost growth from x1.75 to x3.0, moving a full tree from roughly 619k to about 42.2M Terroir. This fixes the number but not the strategy: if the optimal play is still to bank the target total and then use Buy All, the skill tree is functioning as a delayed unlock rather than an evolving build.

Design goal

A player should regularly face a meaningful question such as "Do I deepen Grove, unlock Press efficiency, or invest in Estate automation this Vintage?" A banked currency total should not eliminate that decision.

Recommended hybrid: Terroir + Knowledge

- Terroir remains the economic cost of learning ranks.
- Knowledge (or another non-spendable progression score) controls how far into the tree the player is allowed to go.
- Knowledge is earned from activity that proves progression: Vintages completed, new production tiers reached, meaningful personal-best milestones, or branch-relevant achievements.
- A huge early Vintage can make the player rich in Terroir, but it cannot instantly skip the experiential progression of the lineage.

Example gating

Node	Terroir cost	Additional requirement
Pollinators	250 T	75 total Trees or Grove Knowledge 3
Second Pressing	1,000 T	25 total Presses or Press Knowledge 3
Vintage Chart	25,000 T	10M lifetime Bottles or Cellar Knowledge 7
Estate Manager	100,000 T	5 Vintages + 1 Succession
Branch capstone	High	Branch milestone + lineage progression

Simpler version if you do not want another resource

- Gate skill-tree depth by Vintage count and branch-specific production milestones.
- Example: tier 1 opens immediately, tier 2 after Vintage 3, tier 3 after Vintage 7, tier 4 after Vintage 15, capstones after first Succession.
- Keep Buy All as quality-of-life, but only allow it to buy currently unlocked depth.

3. Replace tending spam with a charged active-play mechanic

Current tending is triggered on every Space keydown. Keyboard repeat therefore turns "hold Space" into built-in autoclicking. That rewards input frequency, not judgement.

Recommended: make Vigour the cost of tending

Vigour already exists, so the game does not need a new concept. Let it charge over time and make the Tend action cash out that charge. The player can Tend early for a smaller reward or wait for a full-strength harvest.

Vigour	Illustrative reward	Purpose
25%	2 seconds of Grove production	Quick interruption / emergency cash
50%	5 seconds	Useful but not optimal
75%	9 seconds	Strong active timing
100%	15 seconds + burst bonus	Default optimal Tend

Autumn redesign

Instead of "tending x4" rewarding even more spam, Autumn could make Vigour charge 4x faster, increase perfect-harvest payout, or grant a short chain bonus for landing full-Vigour Tends. This creates a seasonal active-play event without requiring repetitive key input.

Input safeguard

- Ignore repeated keydown events (`e.repeat`) so keyboard auto-repeat can never be the intended optimisation.
- Keep mouse/touch Tend available, but apply the same Vigour rules.

4. Make Cultivars powerful enough to justify a Lineage

A Lineage is the rarest and most destructive reset. It removes the current heirloom stack, Terroir and skill-tree progression. The permanent reward should therefore feel qualitatively different from the bonuses earned at lower prestige layers.

Rule of thumb

Heirlooms and the Skill Tree should mostly change numbers. Cultivars should change rules.

Windfall Stock - Current: Press may take entire crop. **Proposed:** Pressed Fruit still contributes a percentage of its value to spendable Fruit, removing the capital-starvation penalty.

Cold Cellar - Current: Cellar runs full-rate offline. **Proposed:** Entire estate runs at 100% offline efficiency; Cellar also ignores offline cap.

Perennial Roots - Current: Keep 25% of Trees through Vintage. **Proposed:** Keep a meaningful portion of Tree counts plus one Grove upgrade tier / milestone.

Deep Taproot - Current: +12h offline cap. **Proposed:** Unlimited offline duration with diminishing efficiency after 24h.

Even Year - Current: No off-season penalty. **Proposed:** No off-season penalty and non-featured stages still receive a modest seasonal bonus.

Grafted Stock - Current: Trees cost 30% less. **Proposed:** Keep largely as-is; this directly attacks the exponential Tree-cost wall.

Terroir Memory - Current: Keep 10% Terroir through Succession. **Proposed:** Keep 25-30% Terroir and preserve one chosen skill-tree branch through Succession.

Cellar Overflow - Current: Standing Must ages slowly. **Proposed:** Standing Must auto-ages at a substantial fraction of normal Cellar capacity.

Hands Free - Current: Auto-tend twice/sec. **Proposed:** Automatically cash out full-Vigour Tends; converts the active system into true automation.

Long Lineage - Current: Heirloom value +40% vs +25%. **Proposed:** Keep concept, but consider +50% or another major lineage-wide scaling effect.

Add a baseline reward for every Lineage

The player should never complete a Lineage and feel that the only result is an unusable Seed sitting in the bank. Give every completed Lineage a permanent baseline bonus independent of Seed spending.

- Illustrative: x1.5 all production per Lineage.
- Illustrative: x1.10 to x1.15 Terroir gain per Lineage.
- Or use a softer compounding model if multiplicative scaling is too aggressive.

This creates two rewards at once:

- The Lineage itself is permanent progression.
- Seeds buy the dramatic mechanical transformations.

5. Give each prestige layer a distinct job

Layer	Typical cadence	What resets	Primary reward	Player question
Vintage	Minutes to hours	Run resources/building s/upgrades	Terroir + Knowledge / skill access	"What can I improve next run?"
Succession	Several Vintages	Terroir + whole skill tree	Heirlooms + deeper automation/access	"Is the permanent multiplier worth rebuilding?"
Lineage	Several Successions	Heirlooms + Terroir + tree	Seeds + rule-changing Cultivars + Lineage bonus	"Which permanent rule do I want to change next?"

The intended rhythm

1. Short term: another Vintage visibly buys a small number of meaningful skills.
2. Medium term: a cluster of Vintages builds enough lifetime Terroir to make a Succession attractive.
3. Long term: several Successions move the player toward a specific Cultivar that will materially change the next Lineage.

North-star feeling

The player should always be able to point at the next transformation: a new branch mechanic, a new automation rule, a much stronger Succession, or a Cultivar that changes the estate. Progress should not collapse into "wait until the number is big enough to Buy All."

6. Treat the new 200-building milestone as an endgame target

The current update extends each production stage to 22 building tiers and adds a fifth per-tier upgrade at 200 owned (x3). That is useful long-game content, but the normal progression loop should not require 200 of every tier before a Vintage. Exponential x1.175 building costs make that a completion/final-run objective by design.

Recommended pacing

Milestone	Normal-run role	Endgame role
10 / 25	Fast snowball milestones	Routine
50	Mid-run production milestone	Routine
100	Late normal-run milestone	Common target once permanent power is high enough
200	Do not force every Vintage	Completion / final-run / very high-lineage target

7. Implementation priority

The changes can be staged. The first four are the ones most likely to improve the game immediately without requiring a full rebalance of every number.

Priority	Change	Design value	Engineering / balance risk
P0	Block Space key-repeat and redesign Tend around Vigour	High	Low
P0	Separate Press capital from Fruit	Very high	Medium-high
P0	Add progression gates to the Skill Tree	Very high	Medium
P0	Strengthen Cultivars / add Lineage baseline reward	Very high	Medium-high
P1	Clarify prestige-layer roles in UI copy and targets	High	Low
P1	Tune 200-building upgrades as endgame, not normal-run expectations	Medium-high	Medium
P2	Add richer branch-specific milestone requirements	Medium	Medium
P2	Revisit automation after the new active-play loop is stable	Medium	Low-medium

8. How to tell whether the redesign worked

- A competent player no longer intentionally leaves Press underdeveloped solely to preserve Fruit for buying more Press.
- Players buy meaningful skill ranks across multiple Vintages instead of saving a single target amount and purchasing 472/472 in one burst.
- Holding Space provides no advantage over deliberate tending.
- A new Cultivar changes the player's strategy or removes a constraint they previously planned around.
- Lineage remains attractive even when the next Seed cannot immediately be spent.
- The player can explain the job of each prestige layer in one sentence: Vintage = build, Succession = power, Lineage = rules.

- The 200-building milestone feels like aspirational endgame content rather than an obligation on every ordinary Vintage.

Recommended target state

Economy

Grove, Press and Cellar each have a self-funding capital loop; their outputs still feed one another, but they do not all fight for the same wallet.

Skill tree

Terroir pays for skills, while play milestones control what can be learned. The tree is a build that develops, not a shopping list purchased at the end.

Active play

Tending is a timed harvest decision built around Vigour. Active players gain through attention and timing, not repetitive input.

Long game

Cultivars remove constraints and change rules. Each Lineage itself also grants permanent progress, so the rare reset always feels consequential.

Appendix: current-system observations used in this review

These are factual observations from the current HTML supplied for the game; the redesign recommendations above are design proposals, not claims about existing behaviour.

- Trees and Presses currently use Fruit as their purchase currency; Casks use Must.
- Presses intercept live Grove production before the remainder reaches the Fruit stockpile.
- The current skill tree contains 472 ranks. Rank-price growth is x3.0, and the source comment states a full tree is about 42.2M Terroir.
- The update contains 22 Grove tiers, 22 Press tiers and 22 Cellar tiers.
- Per-building upgrade milestones are 10, 25, 50, 100 and 200 owned; the 200 milestone grants x3.
- The current long-game source comments describe all Cultivars as taking many Lineages to collect.
- The keyboard handler currently triggers Tend on Space keydown and does not explicitly reject repeat events.

Source: current Orchard & Cellar HTML supplied in this conversation, 24 August 2026.